

Noel D. Johnson

George Mason University
Department of Economics
4400 University Drive, MSN 1D3
Fairfax, VA 22030-4444

Phone: +1 314.420.5735
Email: njohnsoL@gmu.edu
Homepage: noeldjohnson.github.io

Current Affiliations

2022-Present Professor, Economics Department, George Mason University
2008-Present Center for the Study of Public Choice, George Mason University
2008-Present Research Fellow, Mercatus Center at George Mason University

Previous Appointments

2014-2022 Associate Professor, George Mason University
2008-2014 Assistant Professor, George Mason University
2007-2008 Visiting Assistant Professor, SUNY at Buffalo
2006-2007 Visiting Assistant Professor, The Hobart and William Smith Colleges
2004-2007 Assistant Professor, California State University–Long Beach (on leave 2006-2007)

Editorial Positions

2025- Associate Editor, *Explorations in Economic History*
2020- Editorial Board, *Journal of Economics, Management, and Religion*

Education

1998-2004 Ph.D, Economics, Washington University in St. Louis
1991-1995 B.A., Economics and History, Kenyon College

Research Interests

Primary: Economic History
Secondary: Applied Econometrics, GIS, and Text as Data
Environmental Shocks
State Capacity

Books

- 2019 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2019). *Persecution & Toleration: The Long Road to Religious Freedom*. Cambridge University Press

Refereed Publications

- 2024 | Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2023). Pandemics and Cities: Evidence from the Black Death. *Journal of Urban Economics*
- 2022 | Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2022). The Economic Impact of the Black Death. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 60(1):132–78
- 2021 | Finley, T., Franck, R., and Johnson, N. D. (2021). The Effects of Land Redistribution: Evidence from the French Revolution. *The Journal of Law and Economics*, 64(2):233–267
- 2020 | Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2020). Medieval Cities Through the Lens of Urban Economics. *Regional Science and Urban Economics*, page 103598
- 2019 | Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2019). Negative shocks and mass persecutions: evidence from the black death. *Journal of Economic Growth*, 24(4):345–395
- 2017 | Anderson, R. W., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2017). Jewish persecutions and weather shocks: 1100–1800. *The Economic Journal*, 127(602):924–958 (*Awarded Best Paper of the Year*)
- 2017 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2017b). States and economic growth: Capacity and constraints. *Explorations in Economic History*, 64:1–20
- 2017 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2017a). Jewish communities and city growth in preindustrial Europe. *Journal of Development Economics*, 127:339 – 354
- 2016 | Franck, R. and Johnson, N. D. (2016). Can public policies lower religiosity? Evidence from school choice in France, 1878-1902. *The Economic History Review*, 69(3):915–944
- 2014 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2014b). Taxes, lawyers, and the decline of witch trials in France. *Journal of Law & Economics*, 57(1)
- 2014 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2014a). Tax farming and the origins of state capacity in England and France. *Explorations in Economic History*, 51:1–20 (*Lead Article*)

- | | |
|------|---|
| 2014 | Johnson, N. D., Ruger, W., Sorens, J., and Yamarik, S. (2014). Corruption, regulation, and growth: An empirical study of the United States. <i>Economics of Governance</i> , 15(1):51–69 |
| 2014 | Franck, R., Johnson, N. D., and Nye, J. V. C. (2014). From internal taxes to national regulation: Evidence from a French wine tax reform at the turn of the twentieth century. <i>Explorations in Economic History</i> , 51:77–93 |
| 2013 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2013). Legal centralization and the birth of the secular state. <i>Journal of Comparative Economics</i> , 41(4):959–978 (<i>Lead Article</i>) |
| 2012 | Johnson, N. D. and Mislin, A. (2012). How much should we trust the world values survey trust question? <i>Economics Letters</i> , 116:110–112 |
| 2011 | Johnson, N. D. and Mislin, A. (2011). Trust games: A meta-analysis. <i>Journal of Economic Psychology</i> , 32:865–889 |
| 2011 | Johnson, N. D. and Nye, J. V. C. (2011). Does fortune favor dragons? <i>Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization</i> , 78(1-2) |
| 2011 | Johnson, N. D., Lafountain, C. L., and Yamarik, S. (2011). Corruption is bad for growth (even in the United States). <i>Public Choice</i> , 147(3-4):377–393 |
| 2010 | Compton, R., Johnson, N. D., and Yamarik, S. (2010b). War! What is it good for? <i>BE Press: Peace Economics, Peace Science, and Public Policy</i> , 16(1) |
| 2010 | Compton, R., Giedeman, D., and Johnson, N. D. (2010a). Investing in institutions. <i>Economics and Politics</i> , 22(3) |
| 2009 | Balla, E. and Johnson, N. D. (2009). Fiscal crisis and institutional change in the Ottoman Empire and France. <i>Journal of Economic History</i> , 69(03):809–845 |
| 2006 | Johnson, N. D. (2006a). Banking on the king: The evolution of the royal revenue farms in Old Regime France. <i>Journal of Economic History</i> , 66(4):963–91 |
| 2006 | Johnson, N. D. (2006b). The cost of credibility: The company of general farms and fiscal stagnation in eighteenth century France. <i>Essays in Economic and Business History</i> , 24:16–28 |

Other Publications

- | | |
|------|---|
| 2018 | Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2018). The state, toleration, and religious freedom. In Iyer, L., Rubin, J., and Carvalho, J.-P., editors, <i>Advances in the Economics of Religion</i> . Palgrave MacMillan |
| 2018 | Johnson, N. D. (2018). Geospatial information systems. In Blum, M. and Colvin, C. L., editors, <i>An Economist's Guide to Economic History</i> . Palgrave MacMillan |

- | | |
|------|--|
| 2016 | Johnson, N. D. (2016). Review of Vincent J. Pitts, ‘Embezzlement and High Treason in Louis XIV’s France: The Trial of Nicolas Fouquet’. <i>EH.net Economic History Services</i> |
| 2015 | Johnson, N. D., Koyama, M., and Nye, J. V. C. (2015). Establishing a new order: The growth of the state and the decline of witch trials in France. In Greif, A., Kiesling, L., and Nye, J. V. C., editors, <i>Institutions, Innovation, and Industrialization</i> . Princeton University Press |
| 2014 | Johnson, N. D. (2014). Review of Guy Rowlands, ‘The financial decline of a great power: War, influence, and money in Louis XIV’s France’. <i>Journal of Economic History</i> , 74(4):1225–1226 |
| 2012 | Johnson, N. D. (2012b). Review of Jan Luiten Van Zanden, ‘The long road to the industrial revolution: The european economy in a global perspective, 1000-1800’. <i>Journal of Economic History</i> , 72(3) |
| 2012 | Johnson, N. D. (2012c). Review of Mark Dincecco, ‘Political transformations and public finances: Europe, 1650-1913’. <i>Journal of Economic History</i> , 72(4) |
| 2012 | Johnson, N. D. (2012a). Review of James Simpson, ‘creating wine: The emergence of a world industry, 1840-1914’. <i>EH.net Economic History Services</i> |
| 2007 | Johnson, N. D. (2007). Review of Jeff Horn, ‘The path not taken: French industrialization in the age of revolution’. <i>EH.net Economic History Services</i> |
| 2003 | Johnson, N. D. (2003). Banking on bureaucrats: The emergence of bureaucracy in old regime france. In <i>Proceedings of the National Tax Association</i> |
| 2001 | Johnson, N. D. (2001). Committing to civil service reform: The performance of pre-shipment inspection under differing institutional regimes. <i>World Bank Policy Research Paper No. 2594</i> |

Working Papers & Research in Progress

- | | |
|------|---|
| 2026 | Johnson, N. D. and Wilhelm, E. (2026). Craft Guilds & City Growth in Western Europe, 1000–1800, <i>Research in Progress</i> |
| 2026 | Johnson, N. D. (2026). Honor, Heredity and Wages: Testing the Great Chain of Being and Compensating Differentials in Pre-Industrial Europe, <i>Research in Progress</i> |
| 2025 | Johnson, N. D., Taylor, A., and Thomas, A. (2025). The Impact of the Black Death on the Adoption of the Printing Press, <i>Revise and Resubmit at Journal of Economic History</i> |

2025	Hussain, M. A. and Johnson, N. D. (2025). The Great Revolt and its Legacy: Understanding Vaccine Hesitancy in Colonial India, <i>Under Review</i>
2025	Johnson, N. D. and Taylor, A. (2025a). Mapping the Market for Ideas in Europe, 1450–1650: A Title-Embeddings Approach, <i>Research in Progress</i>
2025	Johnson, N. D. and Taylor, A. (2025b). Production Is Not Exposure: Plague, Print, and Persecution in Early Modern Europe, <i>Research in Progress</i>

Invited Presentations and Visiting Positions

Brown University Conference on Deep Rooted Factors in Development, Fall 2026
 Mercatus Center, Applied AI Working Group, Summer 2026
 Markets and Society Conference, Mercatus Center, Fall 2025
 University of Mississippi, Spring 2024
 University of Pittsburgh, Fall 2022
 London School of Economics, Fall 2022
 Virginia Tech, Spring 2022
 Texas Tech, Spring 2022
 University of Connecticut, Spring 2022
 International Macro History Seminar, CEPR & Graduate Institute of Geneva, Spring 2021
 University of Colorado, Benson Center for the Study of Western Civilization, Spring 2021
 Paris School of Economics, Spring 2021 (Visitor)
 University of Colorado, Fall 2020
 Auburn University, Spring 2020
 Tulane University, Spring 2020
 Bocconi University, Milan, Fall 2019
 University of Manchester, Fall 2019
 Paris School of Economics, Fall 2019 (Visitor)
 NYU, Abu Dhabi, Spring 2019
 Bocconi University, Milan, Spring 2019
 Paris 1 Pantheon-Sorbonne, Paris, Fall 2018 (Visitor)
 Northwestern University, Fall 2018
 CESifo, Munich, Spring, 2018 (Visitor)
 University of Copenhagen, Spring, 2018
 University of Southern Denmark, Spring, 2018
 Wake Forest University, Winston-Salem, Fall, 2017
 American University, Fall 2017
 Hebrew University, Jerusalem, Spring 2017 (Visitor)
 Yale University, New Haven, Fall 2016
 Humboldt University, Berlin, Summer 2016

IOEA, Corsica, Summer 2016
Brown University Conference on Deep Rooted Factors in Development, Spring 2016
American University, Spring 2016
Banque de France, Paris, Fall 2015
University of Maryland, History Dept., Spring 2015
Stellenbosch University, South Africa, Summer 2015
Columbia University/Barnard University Economic History Seminar, Fall 2014
Brown University Conference on Deep Rooted Factors in Development, Spring 2014
University of Vermont, Spring 2014
Northwestern University, Fall 2013
Rutgers University, Fall 2013
NES & HSE Conference on Culture and Diversity, Moscow, Fall 2013
Stanford University, Spring 2013
Chapman University, Spring 2013
The Elliott School of International Affairs, Spring 2013
Caltech, Spring 2013
Harvard University, Fall 2011
American University, Fall 2010
SUNY at Buffalo, Spring 2008
Guelph University, Fall 2007
University of California-Riverside, Spring 2006
University of Manitoba, Spring 2006
University of Vermont, Fall 2005
University of California-Los Angeles, Spring 2005
Washington University in St. Louis, Spring 2002
World Bank Tax and Policy Administration Group, Spring 2001

Teaching Experience

Empirical Techniques in Spatial Economics
Text as Data and Machine Learning
European Economic History
American Economic History
Economic Growth and Development
Intermediate Micro and Macro

Service

Organizer of Washington Area Economic History & Development Workshop, 2010-Present
 Organizer of Washington Area Economic History Seminar, 2011-Present
 College Study Leave Committee, 2019
 College Promotion and Tenure Committee, 2017-18
 College Curriculum Committee, Fall 2010, Spring 2011
 Writing Assessment Evaluator, Spring 2013
 Organizer of Economics Department Public Choice Seminar, 2010, 2011, 2012, 2013, 2014, 2015 (spring), 2021, 2022
 Economic History Field Exam Committee, 2009-Present
 Referee for *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *National Science Foundation*, *The Economic Journal*, *American Economic Journal: Policy*, *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *Journal of Economic History*, *Journal of Economic Psychology*, *Contemporary Economic Policy*, *Journal of Institutional Economics*, *Economics & Politics*, *American Political Science Review*, *Essays in Business and Economic History*, *Public Choice*, *Journal of Development Economics*, *Journal of Economic Growth*, *Journal of Economics, Management, and Religion*
 Presented at OLLI, 2009, 2011, 2012, 2014, 2015, 2017, 2018
 Course Coordinator for Principles Classes, Spring 2006
 Curriculum Committee, Spring 2004 to Fall 2005
 Library Committee, Spring 2004 to Spring 2005
 Elections Committee, Fall 2005 to Spring 2005

Awards, Honors, and Grants

Royal Economic Society Prize for best paper in the *Economic Journal*, 2017
 Washington University Senior Teaching Fellow, (Fall 2002, 2003)
 California State University, Competitive Research Grant, (Fall, Spring 2006)
 Washington University Competitive Research Grant, (2002, 2001, 1999)
 Center for New Institutional Social Sciences Competitive Research Grant, (2000)
 Kenyon College, Baker Prize for historical writing, (Spring 1994)
 Invited Participant, Lehrman Teaching Institute, Princeton, N.J., (Summer 2006)
 METTRANS Transportation Center Competitive Research Grant (with Kristen Monaco), (Spring 2006)
 Sage Fellow, Cornell University, (Fall 1995)
 Washington University Dissertation Completion Fellowship, (Summer 2002, 2003)
 Phi Beta Kappa, (Spring 1995)

References

Professor Joel Mokyr
Northwestern University
Department of Economics
Anderson 3214
2001 Sheridan Road
Evanston, IL 60208
847-491-5693
j-mokyr@northwestern.edu

Professor Nathan Nunn
University of British Columbia
Department of Economics
Iona Building, 6000 Iona Drive
Vancouver, BC V6T 2E8

nathan.nunn@ubc.ca

Professor John Wallis
University of Maryland
Department of Economics
College Park, MD 20742
301-405-3552
wallis@econ.umd.edu

Last updated: September 23, 2026